TECHNICAL ADVISORY · DEPLOYMENT

CONFIDENTIAL

Hosting & Deployment Analysis

A plain-English guide to taking the Membership Management Platform live on **193cc.co.uk** — what it needs, the UK hosting options, fair-price costings, and the route to go live.

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Project: Membership Management Platform
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1 Executive summary

The platform is built and demo-ready. To run it as a live service on your new domain, it needs modern web hosting — not the traditional shared hosting used for brochure websites. This document explains why, in plain terms, and gives you clear, fairly-priced UK options.

RECOMMENDED LAUNCH COST

£15–30/mo

UK-hosted, all-in, indicative & ex-VAT

DATA LOCATION

United Kingdom

London / EU region — GDPR aligned

TIME TO GO LIVE

~2 days

from receiving DNS access

> **The headline:** a members' portal of this kind does **not** require heavyweight enterprise infrastructure. Hosted correctly, it runs comfortably on a small UK cloud server for around **£15–20 per month** at launch. This is the **entry-level baseline**; as event video, photo galleries and full member portal access are added, cost grows in planned stages — set out in §6.

The remainder of this document covers: what the application is and why hosting choice matters (§2), the exact server specification (§3), a side-by-side comparison of UK hosting options (§4), our recommendation (§5), a transparent cost, scaling and future growth-path breakdown (§6), data-protection and security provisions (§7), the go-live plan (§8), and what we need from you to proceed (§9). A plain-English glossary is provided at the end.

2 Understanding the platform

The Membership Management Platform is a **web application**, not a static website. A brochure website simply displays fixed pages. This platform actively *does* things: it enrols members, verifies their identity and company, takes signatures and payments, stores documents, and gives your team a secure admin console — all backed by a live database.

Why traditional shared hosting is not suitable

The "500 MB / 1 GB bandwidth" shared-hosting packages currently in use are designed for simple PHP or static sites. They cannot run this application, which requires a proper application runtime, a database engine, and background processing. The good news: the alternative is inexpensive.

The platform needs…	Because it…	Shared hosting?
A Node.js application runtime	Runs live server logic for every enrolment, login and admin action	✗ Not provided
A PostgreSQL database	Stores members, memberships, payments, documents and the audit trail	✗ Not provided
Persistent file storage	Holds uploaded organisation documents securely	✗ Limited / unsafe
Background scheduler	Runs deadlines, reminders and instalment processing automatically	✗ Not provided
HTTPS / TLS certificate	Encrypts all member data in transit	~ Sometimes

In short: the platform needs a small **cloud server (VPS)** or a **managed application platform** — both covered next — rather than a shared hosting account.

3 Technical specification

This is the specification to provision for launch. It comfortably serves a members' portal with peaks around Summit events. Figures in brackets give recommended headroom.

Component	Requirement	Notes
Operating system	Ubuntu Linux 24.04 LTS	Long-term-support, secure, industry standard
Processor (CPU)	2 vCPU (4 recommended)	Handles concurrent members and admin activity
Memory (RAM)	4 GB (8 GB recommended)	Runs the app and database comfortably
Storage	80 GB SSD / NVMe	Application, database and member documents
Application runtime	Node.js 20 LTS	The framework the platform is built on
Database	PostgreSQL 16	Note: PostgreSQL, not MySQL
Monthly bandwidth	2–4 TB included	Any cloud server includes this as standard
Security certificate	TLS via Let's Encrypt	Free, auto-renewing HTTPS
Transactional email	SMTP provider (Postmark / Brevo / SES)	Sends verification codes, contracts, receipts
Data region	United Kingdom (London) / EU	For data residency & GDPR

> **Note on the earlier draft spec.** An initial infrastructure estimate was scoped for ~10,000 daily active users on a large managed cluster (~£450–500/month). That sizing suits a mass-market consumer app; for a consortium members' portal it is many times larger than required. The right-sized specification above delivers the same platform at a fraction of the running cost.

4 UK hosting options compared

Three sensible routes, all keeping data in the UK/EU. Costs are indicative monthly figures, ex-VAT.

Option	What it is	Indicative £/mo	Maintenance
B. UK Cloud Server (VPS) RECOMMENDED	One UK server runs the whole platform. Full control and UK data sovereignty. Providers: IONOS (Slough), DigitalOcean (London), Krystal (UK), UpCloud (London).	£12–20	Managed by us
A. Managed platform ZERO-OPS	Application and database run on a fully-managed service (Vercel + Neon, London region). Nothing to maintain; scales automatically.	£30–45	None (automatic)
C. Managed containers MIDDLE GROUND	Managed app hosting in a UK region (Fly.io London, DigitalOcean App Platform). Balance of control and convenience.	£15–25	Shared

Option B — UK VPS REC

- ✓ Lowest, flat, predictable cost
- ✓ Data physically in the UK
- ✓ Full control & flexibility
- — We handle updates & backups (included in support)

Option A — Managed ALT

- ✓ No server maintenance at all
- ✓ Automatic scaling & backups
- ✓ Fastest possible launch
- — US-headquartered vendors (data still stored in London)
- — Higher monthly cost

5 Our recommendation

> **Recommended: Option B — a UK Cloud Server (VPS).** It gives the Consortium the best combination of **fair price**, **UK data sovereignty**, and **full control**, at roughly **£12–20/month**. We provision, secure, deploy and maintain it for you. Should you prefer a completely hands-off, self-scaling arrangement, **Option A (managed)** is an excellent alternative at £30–45/month.

Why this fits the Consortium

✓ **Right-sized:** matched to a members' portal, not an over-provisioned cluster.

✓ **UK-hosted:** member data (including uploaded documents and personal details) stays in the UK/EU.

✓ **Predictable:** a flat monthly fee with no surprise usage bills.

✓ **Room to grow:** a simple upgrade path as membership increases (see §6).

6 Cost, scaling & the growth path

> **Read this as the launch baseline.** The figures below cover the platform exactly as built and demonstrated today. As the Consortium adds event **videos and photo galleries**, grows the **member register**, and rolls out **portal logins for the whole membership**, the platform naturally needs more storage, delivery capacity and computing power — so running costs rise in step. This is a planned, staged progression, not a rebuild.

Stage 1 — the platform as it is today

At launch, running cost grows only gently with membership. Indicative monthly figures, ex-VAT.

Stage	Members (approx.)	Server	Hosting £/mo
Launch	up to ~500	2 vCPU / 4 GB VPS	£12–20
Growth	~1,000–2,000	4 vCPU / 8 GB VPS	£30–45
Scale	~5,000+	4 vCPU / 8 GB + managed database + object storage	£60–90

What increases cost as the platform grows

Three things drive the step up from a basic portal to a full media-rich membership system:

Driver	What it adds to the platform	Infrastructure impact
1. Event video & photos	Videos and image galleries must be stored and streamed through a content-delivery network (CDN) so they play smoothly for members worldwide. **This is the single biggest cost driver.**	Object storage + CDN / video streaming
2. Growing member register	More members, memberships, uploaded documents and history to store, back up, secure and report on.	Larger database + backups
3. Portal logins for all members	Many members signed in at once — especially around Summit events — rather than a handful of staff.	More compute + caching / auto-scaling

Stage 2 — full rollout (future state)

With rich media and the full membership using the portal, the recommended shape adds object storage, a CDN / video service, a managed database and scalable compute. Indicative monthly figures, ex-VAT.

Element added	Purpose	Indicative £/mo
Object storage	Durable storage for photos, documents & video (S3 / Cloudflare R2)	£5–20
CDN / video streaming	Fast, smooth global playback (Cloudflare Stream / Bunny)	£15–80+
Managed database	Automatic backups, scaling & reliability	£15–40
Scaled application compute	Handles many concurrent member logins	£30–60
Transactional email (higher volume)	Notifications across the full membership	£10–25
Full-rollout total	**Media-rich portal, full membership active**	**£80–200**

Video delivery is usage-based, so the upper figure depends on how much video members watch. Even at the top of this band the platform stays a fraction of enterprise-cluster pricing, and cost tracks real usage rather than being paid up front. We would scale each element only as the need actually arrives.

What's included today, and the few extras

Item	Detail	Cost
Domain — 193cc.co.uk	Already owned by the Consortium	Owned
HTTPS / TLS certificate	Let's Encrypt, auto-renewing	Free
Companies House verification	Official UK government register API	Free
Transactional email	Verification codes, contracts, receipts	£0–12/mo
Automated backups	Daily database + document backups	£3–6/mo
Payment processing	Stripe / GoCardless — *per-transaction only* at go-live	% per txn

Payments are currently **simulated** for demonstration. Live card / Direct Debit processing is enabled at go-live via Stripe or GoCardless, which charge a small per-transaction fee rather than a monthly cost.

7 Data protection, security & compliance

The platform handles members' personal data and organisation documents, so it is built with protection in mind at every layer.

Area	Provision
Data residency	Hosting in the UK (London) / EU region, supporting UK GDPR obligations
Encryption in transit	All traffic secured with TLS 1.2/1.3 (HTTPS)
Encryption at rest	Database and document storage on encrypted volumes
Access control	Role-based separation — members, sales and administrators each see only what they should
Identity verification	Email-ownership codes + Companies House company & director checks before activation
Tamper-evident records	Append-only audit log and financial ledger — entries cannot be silently altered or deleted
Human oversight	Every organisation is approved by a person; nothing self-approves
Backups & recovery	Automated daily backups with retention

> **Human-in-the-loop by design.** Automation gathers the evidence — the government register check, the verified email, the uploaded documents — but a member of your team always makes the final approval decision. This keeps the Consortium in control of who becomes a member.

8 Go-live plan

Once we have DNS access for 193cc.co.uk and your hosting decision, the platform can be live within approximately **two working days**.

1. **Provision** the UK server and secure it (firewall, updates, monitoring).
2. **Point the domain** — configure DNS so 193cc.co.uk resolves to the new server.
3. **Deploy** the application and database; issue the HTTPS certificate.
4. **Configure integrations** — transactional email and live Companies House checks.
5. **Test end-to-end** — enrolment, verification, payment and the admin/sales views.
6. **Go live** — hand over, with support in place.

9 What we need from you

#	Item	Purpose
1	DNS access for **193cc.co.uk**	To point the domain at the live platform
2	Hosting decision — **Option B (VPS)** or **A (managed)**	So we can provision the right environment
3	Confirm preferred data region (UK / EU)	Data residency
4	A sending email address, e.g. **membership@193cc.co.uk**	For member notifications & verification codes
5	Payment provider preference (Stripe / GoCardless)	To enable live payments at go-live

> **Next step:** confirm items 1 and 2 and we can begin provisioning immediately.

✦ Plain-English glossary

Web application	A website that actively does things (enrol, verify, pay) rather than just displaying fixed pages.
Node.js	The technology that runs the platform's live logic on the server.
PostgreSQL	The secure database that stores members, payments and records.
VPS / Cloud server	A private virtual server in a data centre — like renting your own computer online.
Managed hosting	A service that runs the server for you, with maintenance and scaling handled automatically.
DNS	The internet's address book — it points 193cc.co.uk to the correct server.
TLS / SSL (HTTPS)	Encryption that protects data as it travels between members and the site (the padlock).
Data residency	The country where data is physically stored — the UK/EU, in this case.
Transactional email	Automatic system emails such as verification codes, contracts and receipts.
Companies House API	A live link to the official UK company register, used to verify organisations.

This document is a technical advisory prepared to support the Consortium's hosting decision. Cost figures are indicative, in GBP and ex-VAT, and should be confirmed at the point of purchase. — Version 1.1, 22 July 2026.